support for liberation movements had also become a major concern for India. In February 1966, the prime minister had spoken of China's propensity "to stir up trouble wherever it can."[73] Officials particularly worried about the susceptibility of the northeast, given the outbreak of a Mizo insurgency and stalled talks with the Nagas, who were believed to be seeking Chinese assistance.[74]

Even as India's security and socioeconomic needs created a crucial imperative for the US-India partnership, Gandhi's political vulnerabilities set limits to that partnership. The precedent of prime ministerial responsibility in foreign policy and the lack of interest in the subject among other party leaders had broadly given Gandhi space and authority in foreign policymaking. It also allowed the further concentration of foreign policy decisionmaking in the prime minister's secretariat. It did not, however, mean that other party leaders, who had selected her expecting her to be a weak and pliable premier, did not affect her foreign policy options. Gandhi's awareness of her political constraints made her sensitive to accusations that she was yielding to external pressure.[75] She had told Rusk that the main question in India about her visit would be "have I sold the country?"[76] After her US trip, perhaps in part to buy some time and space, she wrote to Johnson that the attacks had already started on her government and she only expected them to increase.[77]

But her concerns about the political downside of dependence were also real. This became even more apparent to Gandhi after the devaluation of the rupee in 1966. After she had taken office, a cabinet committee had recommended devaluation, but it had been placed on the back burner.[78] During her visit to the US, however, India had agreed to devaluation as part of a package of reforms that the World Bank had wanted. Critics—especially but not solely—on the left accused the government of succumbing to American pressure.[79] Within Congress, moderate-left party leaders used devaluation to attack her.[80] B. K. Nehru laid out for Johnson the "ugly mood" that prevailed in India. Critics targeted not just the prime minister but also Mehta, B. K. Nehru, Finance Minister Sachindra Chaudhuri, and Food and Agriculture Minister Chidambaram (C.) Subramaniam.[81]

Noting the opposition to devaluation in India, National Security Adviser Walt Rostow, who had closely followed the Indian economy for years,